CHAPTER 7 · BEYOND 2040 · UNIT 8 IN THE COURSE

Catastrophe

ca·tas·tro·phe (noun) the misfortune of something

This chapter is still being written. What follows is the author's synopsis.

The Catastrophe chapter carries the story from projection to reality — from what the mathematics predict to what a society looks like when the bill for 130 years of structural failure finally arrives in full.

This chapter will address the terminus of the arc established in previous chapters: the demographic wave completing its passage, the trust fund clock running out, the first full generation of Americans who lived entirely within the defined-contribution system reaching old age with wholly inadequate resources. It will examine what mass elder poverty looks like not as an abstraction but as a lived social reality — in families, in communities, in the political system that will face its consequences.

It will also return to the themes introduced in the Classical chapter — the ancient questions about what a society owes its aging members — and ask what those questions look like when the improvised answers of the last 130 years have definitively failed.

Catastrophe is not the final word. It is the necessary darkness before the correction. Every chapter of this book has pointed toward what comes next — the principles that outlast every failed experiment, the natural order that reasserts itself when the structures built against it finally collapse.

The catastrophe is not a surprise to anyone who has been watching closely.

Are you watching closely?

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